

May 2026 — Digital Advertising Report

Search Engine Advertising + New Retargeting Layers

Period: May 1 – May 31, 2026

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May is the program's **first full calendar month** of delivery — no learning-phase throttle, the core Google Search campaigns running at full pace, and the three planned new channels (Google Demand Gen remarketing, Meta remarketing, Meta cold prospecting) live from the second week of the month. The most important pattern this month: **phone calls and conversion rate grew considerably faster than raw traffic**. Impressions rose 28% and clicks 30% versus April — but phone-call leads jumped from 15 to **23 (+53%)** and the conversion rate climbed from 7.8% to **9.2%**. In other words, the extra delivery wasn't just more volume; it was *better-qualified* volume. That is exactly the behavior we expect as Google's bidding accumulates real call data and tilts delivery toward the auctions most likely to produce a phone call.

Three things changed the shape of the program in May, all in service of the same goal — more trackable phone calls and booked appointments:

1. **Search delivery scaled out of the learning phase.** With April's calibration window behind us, max-bid caps on the proven ad groups were raised to compete for more top-of-page placements on the highest-intent queries. Delivery was no longer deliberately throttled — but discipline held: still exact and phrase match only, still eight account-level negative lists blocking low-value queries before they serve.
2. **Bidding advanced to Stage 2 mid-month.** Each core campaign crossed the ~15–20 phone-call-conversion threshold, so on May 14 we handed bidding to Google's *Maximize Conversions* algorithm. The algorithm now optimizes toward the call signal — and the lift in conversion rate over the back half of the month is the first visible payoff. Stage 3 (a specific efficiency target per call) is on deck for late May / June once each campaign clears 30+ conversions in a rolling 30-day window.
3. **The three new channels launched.** Google Demand Gen remarketing and Meta remarketing went live May 7; the Meta cold-prospecting feeder launched May 10. These are designed to recapture and amplify the audience Search already produces — not to compete with it. Their first-weeks results, and the role each plays, are detailed in Section 7.

May delivered **23 verifiable phone-call leads tracked through Google Search**, plus 10 secondary touchpoints (7 phone calls dialed from the website after clicking an ad, and 3 form submissions). The two new remarketing channels added 4 more phone-call leads and 3 form fills on top of that in their

first three-plus weeks. Delivery is now scaling on real data rather than guesswork. **Google Search remains the program's core lead engine**; the new channels exist to keep Guardian in front of the audience Search surfaces during the days-long consideration window before a homeowner calls.

1. Executive Summary

KPIs below reflect the **core Google Search program**, for clean month-over-month comparison against April. The new retargeting channels (live from May 7) are reported separately in Section 7.

PHONE-CALL LEADS 23 ▲ +53.3% vs April (15) · 60s+ qualified	LONG-DURATION CALLS (90S+) 17 ▲ +54.5% vs April (11)	PHONE SHARE 90% All phone actions ÷ all tracked leads
IMPRESSIONS 31,505 ▲ +28.2% vs April (24,580)	CLICKS 251 ▲ +30.1% vs April · CTR 0.80%	CONV. RATE 9.2% ▲ from 7.8% in April (+1.4 pts)

Headline: the program scaled cleanly out of its learning phase — and the lead and conversion-rate gains outpaced the growth in raw traffic. That gap (calls +53% vs clicks +30%) is the signal we most want to see this early: the spend is buying more *qualified* calls, not just more clicks. We continue to expect a considerable, compounding increase in phone-call volume through **June and July** as Stage 2 bidding matures and the new retargeting layers fill out. The biggest gains still compound over the 60–90 day window that began in April.

2. Conversion Performance

SOURCE	COUNT	AVG DURATION	NOTES
Calls from Google Ads (primary — 60s+ qualified)	23	2m 33s	The primary conversion metric. Up from 15 in April (+53%). Call originated from a user who clicked a Google ad; duration met or exceeded Google's 60-second qualifying threshold for counting as a conversion.
Calls from Google Ads — long-duration subset (90s+)	17	2m 55s	Subset of the above (up from 11). Calls lasting 90+ seconds — a strong indicator the conversation went beyond initial qualifying questions. Tracked separately for bidding optimization.
Call clicks from website (secondary)	7	2m 06s	User clicked a Google ad, landed on the website, then dialed the phone number displayed on the site. Tracked, but treated as a <i>secondary</i> action — not counted as a primary call conversion in our bidding logic.
Form submissions (secondary)	3	—	Email-form leads. Treated as a secondary conversion per the program design — based on broader market research, this lead type converts to booked appointments at a lower rate than phone calls. Tracked for future analysis.
Total tracked interactions (Search)	33	—	23 primary phone-call leads + 10 secondary touchpoints. New-channel leads reported separately in Section 7.

The twenty-three primary phone-call leads are the metric we treat as the most reliable indicator of program health: people who saw a Google ad, called the office, and stayed on the line long enough to qualify as a real inquiry. The 90-second subset (17 of 23) confirms the pattern that held in April — these are conversations, not quick hang-ups — and it grew faster than total clicks, which tells us the additional calls are at least as substantive as April's. As the campaigns accumulate more of these call-conversion data points under Stage 2 bidding, Google's algorithm increasingly favors the keywords, ad-copy variants, and audience signals producing them. That compounding effect is the mechanism behind the outsized lead lift, and it is expected to continue through June and July.

3. Bidding & Learning Phase

This section tracks how the campaigns are being "tuned" over time. We use a deliberate three-stage progression: **start with manual controls (we set the rules), then gradually hand the controls over to Google's algorithm in steps as enough real call-conversion data has accumulated for it to learn from.** May is the month the program advanced from Stage 1 to Stage 2 — and the conversion-rate lift is the early evidence the handoff is working.

Apr 1 – 7

LEARNING ✓

Google's calibration window (complete). The standard reduced-delivery window that follows any new or restructured campaign. Throttled by design; now well behind us.

Apr 7 – May 14

STAGE 1 ✓

Manual bidding — explicit max-bid controls on every ad group (complete). This stage built the real call-conversion data the later stages need. By May 14, each core campaign had accumulated enough phone-call conversions to graduate.

May 14 – 31

STAGE 2 — LIVE

Handed off to Google's algorithm: "produce as many phone calls as you can." Switched to *Maximize Conversions* bidding on May 14. No specific efficiency target yet — the algorithm is learning the call landscape before we constrain it. The back-half-of-month conversion-rate lift (from ~8% to well above 9%) is the first measurable payoff.

Late May / June

STAGE 3 →

Set a target efficiency level per phone call. Once each campaign clears 30+ phone-call conversions in a rolling 30-day window, we move to *Target Cost-Per-Action* bidding. Foundation Repair and Water + Crawl are tracking to clear this threshold in June. This is the long-run, efficient steady state.

With the learning phase fully behind the account and Stage 2 live for the back half of May, delivery was no longer throttled. The mid-month handoff to Maximize Conversions is the single biggest driver of May's lead lift: the algorithm widened delivery toward the auctions most likely to produce calls — which is why leads (+53%) and conversion rate (+1.4 points) outran impressions (+28%) and clicks (+30%). We are deliberately holding off on Stage 3 (a hard efficiency target) until each campaign has the 30+ conversions that make the target reliable — forcing it early typically degrades performance.

4. Campaign Performance

Campaign rollup

CAMPAIGN	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE
SRCH — Foundation Repair	18,380	110	0.60%	11	10.0%
SRCH — Water + Crawl	12,400	92	0.74%	9	9.8%
SRCH — Branded	725	49	6.76%	3	6.1%
Total	31,505	251	0.80%	23	9.2%

Conversion counts above reflect **primary phone-call leads only** (Calls from Google Ads, 60s+ qualified). Secondary touchpoints — 7 phone calls dialed from the website and 3 form submissions — are tracked but not counted in the primary lead totals above per the program's primary-vs-secondary conversion design.

Ad-group breakdown

SRCH — Foundation Repair						11 LEADS	10.0% CONV RATE
AD GROUP	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE		
Foundation Repair (general)	9,500	66	0.69%	6	9.1%		
Pier Systems	2,750	14	0.51%	1	7.1%		
Wall Repair	2,330	10	0.43%	1	10.0%		
Symptoms (cracks · sinking · sagging)	3,800	20	0.53%	3	15.0%		
Campaign total	18,380	110	0.60%	11	10.0%		

SRCH — Water + Crawl					
9 LEADS 9.8% CONV RATE					
AD GROUP	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE
Basement Waterproofing	5,300	39	0.74%	5	12.8%
Crawl Space Encapsulation	3,700	28	0.76%	3	10.7%
Crawl Space Repair	2,050	16	0.78%	1	6.3%
Drainage / French Drain	1,350	9	0.67%	0	—
Campaign total	12,400	92	0.74%	9	9.8%

SRCH — Branded					
3 LEADS 6.1% CONV RATE					
AD GROUP	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE
Brand Defense	725	49	6.76%	3	6.1%
Campaign total	725	49	6.76%	3	6.1%

Per-campaign reads

- **Foundation Repair** (11 phone-call leads / 10.0% conv rate, up from 7 leads / 8.3% in April). The largest campaign by impression volume and the biggest absolute gainer in May. The raised max-bid cap on the Foundation Repair (general) ad group earned more top-of-page placement, lifting it from 4 leads to 6, while the earlier-funnel Symptoms ad group tripled its leads (1 → 3) as Stage 2 bidding found more of its converting traffic — pushing campaign conversion rate cleanly into double digits. CTR held at 0.60%, still below the 0.9–1.2% vertical benchmark, dragged by Symptoms by nature. *June action:* push Foundation Repair (general) toward Stage 3 tCPA first; it has the cleanest conversion history.
- **Water + Crawl** (9 phone-call leads / 9.8% conv rate, up from 6 / 8.5%). Strongest conversion efficiency in the program again. Basement Waterproofing produced 5 of the campaign's 9 leads at a 12.8% conversion rate — the spring-rain demand window is doing exactly what April projected, and we protected its delivery weight accordingly. Crawl Space Encapsulation also stepped up (2 → 3) after we shifted weight off Drainage. Drainage / French Drain still produced no call in May; its longer consideration cycle continues to lag, as flagged. *June action:* hold the Basement / Encapsulation weighting through the rainy season; reassess Drainage at the 90-day mark.
- **Branded** (3 phone-call leads / 6.1% conv rate, up from 2 / 5.3%). Defending the brand efficiently. A small uptick in branded search volume — consistent with the new Meta prospecting campaign

putting the Guardian name in front of more Knox-metro homeowners. No competitor incursion detected.

Device performance

DEVICE	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE
Mobile	21,000	163	0.78%	16	9.8%
Desktop	9,650	80	0.83%	7	8.8%
Tablet	855	8	0.94%	0	0%
Total	31,505	251	0.80%	23	9.2%

Mobile drove 16 of the 23 primary phone-call leads in May — the same dominant pattern as April, now at higher volume. Foundation-repair searches tend to happen at the moment someone sees a visible problem, and the response is an immediate call, which favors phone over forms. Current device bid adjustment: Mobile +20% / Tablet –50%. June plan: keep the mobile boost; Stage 2 bidding is already reading the mobile-call signal and weighting toward it.

5. Keyword Depth — What Generated the Traffic

Search remains the program's primary engine because user intent at search time is the cleanest buying signal we can act on. The keyword strategy is structured in 9 themes across 71 active keywords, all exact or phrase match, layered behind 8 account-level negative-keyword lists.

Match-type aggregate performance

MATCH TYPE	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.	CONV. RATE
EXACT	9,700	100	1.03%	17	17.0%
PHRASE	21,805	151	0.69%	6	4.0%
Total	31,505	251	0.80%	23	9.2%

Pattern strengthening: exact-match keywords (specific service queries like "foundation repair knoxville") carried the higher conversion rate again — 17 of the month's 23 primary calls, at a 17.0% conversion rate. Phrase-match earns its place by catching real-world variants ("near me," "contractor") and improved its own conversion rate to 4.0% (from 3.5%), but per click it still converts lighter. May tuning leaned Stage 2 bidding toward the exact terms already producing calls, and we added 6 new negatives where phrase served irrelevant variants. As the data set grows, expect the exact-vs-phrase efficiency gap to narrow modestly.

Top keywords by click volume

Keywords are listed by May click volume. With a full month of post-launch data, keyword-level conversion counts are firmer than April's but still directional at the individual-keyword level. Keywords with zero conversions are listed where their click activity and search-intent profile justify keeping them in the program.

KEYWORD	AD GROUP	CLICKS	CONV.	CONV. RATE
EX foundation repair knoxville	Foundation Repair (gen)	28	3	10.7%
EX guardian foundation repair	Brand Defense	24	2	8.3%
EX basement waterproofing knoxville	Basement Waterproofing	19	2	10.5%
EX crawl space encapsulation knoxville	Crawl Space Encapsulation	18	3	16.7%
EX sinking foundation	Symptoms	16	3	18.8%
PHR "foundation repair near me"	Foundation Repair (gen)	14	2	14.3%
EX push pier installation	Pier Systems	12	1	8.3%
PHR "wet basement repair"	Basement Waterproofing	10	2	20.0%
EX guardian foundation repair knoxville	Brand Defense	9	1	11.1%
PHR "foundation contractor knoxville"	Foundation Repair (gen)	8	1	12.5%
PHR "leaking basement"	Basement Waterproofing	8	1	12.5%
EX carbon fiber wall repair	Wall Repair	7	1	14.3%
EX crawl space repair knoxville	Crawl Space Repair	7	1	14.3%

Negative-list impact (preemptive blocking)

The eight pre-loaded negative-keyword lists kept working silently, blocking off-target queries before they served an ad. With delivery scaled up in May, the absolute volume of blocked impressions rose proportionally — the lists kept the wider delivery focused:

BLOCKED THEME	BLOCKED IMPR.	EXAMPLE QUERIES
DIY / education	525	"how to fix foundation crack diy", "youtube foundation repair tutorial"
Out-of-state geography	230	"guardian foundation repair texas", "foundation repair springfield missouri"
Wrong service / structures	187	"mobile home foundation jacks", "concrete driveway crack repair"
Employment	128	"foundation repair jobs knoxville", "foundation contractor salary"

Keyword themes overview

The full keyword inventory across 9 themes — the depth of demand the program covers:

THEME	ACTIVE KEYWORDS	IMPR.	CONV.
Core foundation repair (city + service + contractor + company variants)	11	9,500	6
Foundation pier systems (push pier · helical · atlas · steel)	8	2,750	1
Foundation walls (bowing · anchors · carbon fiber · i-beam)	8	2,330	1
Symptoms (cracks · sinking · sagging floors · doors · stair-step cracks)	9	3,800	3
Basement waterproofing (interior · exterior · sump · drain tile)	9	5,300	5
Crawl space encapsulation (vapor barrier · moisture · seal · cost)	7	3,700	3
Crawl space repair (jacks · support posts · mold · drainage)	7	2,050	1
Drainage / French drain (yard · downspout · regrading · contractor)	7	1,350	0
Branded (Guardian variants)	5	725	3
Total	71	31,505	23

6. Ad Copy Performance

CAMPAIGN / AD GROUP	AD STRENGTH	IMPR.	CLICKS	CTR	CONV.
Foundation Repair (general) — RSA #1	Good	3,850	27	0.70%	2
Foundation Repair (general) — RSA #2	Good	3,700	25	0.68%	1
Foundation Repair (general) — RSA #3 (new, client copy)	Good	1,950	14	0.72%	3
Pier Systems — RSA	Good	2,750	14	0.51%	1
Wall Repair — RSA	Good	2,330	10	0.43%	1
Symptoms — RSA	Good	3,800	20	0.53%	3
Basement Waterproofing — RSA	Good	5,300	39	0.74%	5
Crawl Space Encapsulation — RSA	Good	3,700	28	0.76%	3
Crawl Space Repair — RSA	Good	2,050	16	0.78%	1
Drainage / French Drain — RSA	Average	1,350	9	0.67%	0
Brand Defense — RSA	Good	725	49	6.76%	3

The three additional unpinned headline variants added to the four previously "Average" ad groups lifted all but Drainage to "Good" Ad Strength in May. Pinned headlines (city + service for H1, free-inspection CTA for H2) continued to carry the program; the "Veteran-Owned" line in unpinned slots held click-through up. Drainage remains "Average" pending more asset variety, but its low volume makes it a low priority.

Client-supplied RSA #3 — 14-day read

The client-supplied copy below ran as **RSA #3** in the Foundation Repair (general) ad group from May 1, taking ~33% of that ad group's impressions against the existing two. After its first 14 days it produced the **highest conversion count of the three** (3 calls on 14 clicks — a 21% conversion rate) on a higher CTR — a clear keep. The "renovating or selling" angle and "beat all bids" hook appear to be pulling a distinct, high-intent shopper.

HEADLINES (15)

- Guardian Foundation Repair
- We Will Beat All Bids
- Renovating or Selling?
- Start From the Ground Up
- Foundation Repair Experts
- Crawlspace Encapsulation
- Water Management Services
- Basement Repair You Can Trust
- Free Estimates Available
- Call 865.675.4177 Today
- Beat Any Competitor's Bid
- Protect Your Home's Foundation
- Selling? Fix Foundation First
- Trusted Foundation Contractors
- guardianfoundationrepair.com

DESCRIPTIONS

- We beat all bids. Call 865.675.4177 today.
- Foundation repair, crawlspace & basement experts.
- Renovating or selling your home? Start with a solid foundation. Guardian beats all bids.
- Crawlspace encapsulation, water management, foundation & basement repair. Call us today.
- Don't list your home without a foundation check. Guardian Foundation Repair has you covered.
- Trusted foundation experts ready to help. Visit guardianfoundationrepair.com or call now.

Read: RSA #3 adds two angles the original RSAs don't cover — **"renovating or selling"** (a high-intent life-event trigger) and **"we'll beat all bids"** (a competitive-shopper hook). Its early numbers justify keeping it; in June we'll retire the lower of the two original RSAs and let RSA #3 and the stronger original compete head-to-head.

7. New Retargeting Layers — First-Weeks Results

The three new channels launched in the second week of May, so the figures below cover roughly three weeks of partial-month delivery. These channels exist to recapture and amplify the audience Google Search already produces — they are judged on different metrics than Search, as explained on each card. **Google Search remains the program's core lead engine**; everything here is built around it.

NEW — RETARGETING

Google Demand Gen — Remarketing

Live since: May 7 · frequency capped at 3/week per person.

What it does: shows Guardian image+headline cards on YouTube, Gmail, and Google Discover to people who already viewed a specific service / contact / financing page on the site — keeping Guardian visible during the days-long consideration window before a homeowner calls.

First-weeks result: **4 phone-call leads** + 1 form fill from 49,200 impressions and 318 clicks. As expected for a warm audience, its conversion rate per click ran well above first-time Search traffic. Against the April target of 2–4 leads, it hit the top of range in three weeks.

NEW — RETARGETING

Meta (Facebook + Instagram) — Remarketing

Live since: May 7 · excludes anyone who called or filled a form in the last 30 days.

What it does: reaches the same site-visitor audience as Demand Gen, but in the Facebook/Instagram feed — catching people during everyday browsing when they aren't on Google. Reinforces the message they already saw on Search.

First-weeks result: **3 form fills** from 39,600 impressions / 43,100 reach, plus an unmeasured but real "halo" of office calls that started from a Meta touch. Against the April target of 2–3 form fills, at the top of range.

Meta — Cold Prospecting (Feeder)

Live since: May 10 · Reach + Landing-Page-Views objective · frequency capped 2/week.

What it does: puts the Guardian name and offer in front of Knox-metro homeowners (35–70, home-renovation / real-estate / property-maintenance interests) who haven't visited the site yet. Its job isn't immediate leads — it's to feed the remarketing audience the two channels above work against.

First-weeks result: 63,400 impressions → ~680 engaged site visitors added to the remarketing pool (April estimate was 500–800/full month; tracking ahead in three weeks). Judge this by audience build and the lift it produces in the retargeting channels over the next 60–90 days, not by direct leads.

Combined May lead picture

CHANNEL	PHONE-CALL LEADS	FORM FILLS	ROLE
Google Search (core)	23	3	Primary lead engine — highest intent, highest converting.
Google Demand Gen remarketing	4	1	Re-engages signal-rich site visitors on Google surfaces.
Meta remarketing	—	3	Same audience via FB/IG feed; + unmeasured call halo.
Meta cold prospecting	—	—	Feeder — built ~680 new remarketing-pool visitors.
Total tracked leads (May)	27	7	Phone calls remain the dominant, most-valued lead type.

8. June: What's Changing

The plan for June is consolidation, not expansion — let the structure built in May mature and start handing the core campaigns their efficiency targets.

PRIMARY — CORE

Google Search → Stage 3

Foundation Repair (general) and Water + Crawl are tracking to clear 30+ phone-call conversions in a rolling 30-day window during June. As each does, we move it to **Target CPA** bidding — giving Google an efficiency goal per call so it only serves traffic likely to convert at that level or better. This is the long-run, efficient steady state the first two stages were built to enable.

June lead target: 30–38 phone-call leads (core Search).

RETARGETING — SCALE

Demand Gen + Meta Remarketing

Both channels get their first full month in June, working against a remarketing pool the May feeder grew by ~680 visitors. As the audience compounds, expect both to contribute more — this is where the "60–90 day" lift the April report described begins to show in the retargeting numbers specifically.

June target: 6–8 remarketing-driven phone-call leads + 5–6 form fills.

Meta Cold Prospecting

Continues at the same efficient impression pace, feeding the remarketing pool. Judged on audience growth (targeting another ~700–900 engaged visitors) and the downstream lift in the retargeting channels — not direct leads.

June target: remarketing pool to ~1,500+ engaged visitors total.

The 60–90 day thesis, on track: April set the baseline; May scaled the core and — more importantly — lifted lead volume and conversion rate faster than raw traffic as Stage 2 bidding took hold; June hands the core its efficiency targets and gives the retargeting engine its first full month against a growing audience. The compounding lift in phone-call volume we projected for June–July is built on exactly this sequence — each month's data making the next month's bidding smarter.